

IN PROFILE

Prince Albert

Queen Victoria's husband (1819–1861) was passionate about music and his enthusiasm for Mendelssohn—a fellow German—underlined the composer's success in Britain. Albert was an accomplished pianist and organist, a good singer, and an occasional composer (mainly of songs but also of religious music). He expanded Victoria's court band into a full-size orchestra and made proposals for a National Training School for Music, which was eventually founded in 1873 (replaced by the Royal College of Music in 1882).



MENDELSSOHN PLAYS FOR QUEEN VICTORIA AND PRINCE ALBERT, 1842

Changing reputations

Mendelssohn's stellar reputation declined after his death. In the age of Romanticism, his music was thought by some to be over-polite and sentimental. This mainly applied to his religious music. His oratorios *St. Paul* (1836) and *Elijah* (1846) were popular when first performed, but 50 years later Irish writer George Bernard Shaw referred to